

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Energy and Utilities English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For utility operations staff, energy project managers, grid planners, field supervisors, regulatory affairs teams, renewable-energy developers, customer operations teams, and infrastructure leaders.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Outage coordination

02 Field-work authorization

03 Rate-case evidence

04 Interconnection timeline

05 Asset replacement priorities

06 Storm resource planning

07 Efficiency program explanation

08 Reliability dashboard

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Outage coordination

A utility team updates an interruption response.

Roles: Outage coordinator / Customer operations lead

Outage coordinator: We have confirmed interruptions in two service areas. Field assessment is still underway.

Customer operations lead: Customers are asking for restoration times. What can we state accurately?

Outage coordinator: The affected areas and our next update time. We don't yet have a verified restoration estimate.

Customer operations lead: I'll use that wording and separate reported faults from confirmed outages.

Outage coordinator: I'll relay field-verified changes through the incident channel.

Customer operations lead: I'll capture priority customer concerns and route them through the established response process.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Customers are asking for restoration times. What can we state accurately?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Field-work authorization

A crew coordinator clarifies a work package.

Roles: Field supervisor / Control-room coordinator

Field supervisor: The job package references an earlier switching plan. We need the current authorized version before proceeding.

Control-room coordinator: Keep the work pending while the responsible team checks the documentation and required approvals.

Field supervisor: I'll confirm the equipment identifiers and report the discrepancy through the approved channel.

Control-room coordinator: We'll resolve it under the applicable operating procedure; this call doesn't substitute for authorization.

Field supervisor: I'll brief the crew on the pending status.

Control-room coordinator: I'll confirm when the controlled documentation and authorized instructions are available through the proper process.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The job package references an earlier switching plan. We need the current authorized version before proceeding." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Rate-case evidence

A utility prepares an explanation for a proposed investment.

Roles: Regulatory analyst / Asset manager

Regulatory analyst: The filing links this investment to reliability improvement. What evidence supports the expected benefit?

Asset manager: Condition assessments and failure history support replacement, but the benefit estimate depends on assumptions.

Regulatory analyst: Identify those assumptions and distinguish forecast effects from measured results.

Asset manager: I'll provide the alternatives considered and the cost basis.

Regulatory analyst: We also need consistent definitions and the reporting period for the historical figures.

Asset manager: I'll reconcile the evidence package before it goes through the filing review.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The filing links this investment to reliability improvement. What evidence supports the expected benefit?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Interconnection timeline

A renewable-project team asks about grid connection.

Roles: Project developer / Interconnection coordinator

Project developer: Can we announce a connection date now that the application is accepted?

Interconnection coordinator: Application acceptance isn't permission to connect. Studies, agreements, and other applicable requirements remain.

Project developer: Which milestones should our schedule show?

Interconnection coordinator: Use the current process and confirmed dependencies, with provisional dates clearly labeled.

Project developer: I'll revise the investor update to distinguish queue status from an approved operating date.

Interconnection coordinator: I'll confirm the next review stage and the information your team needs to provide.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Can we announce a connection date now that the application is accepted?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Asset replacement priorities

A utility compares two maintenance investments.

Roles: Asset engineer / Maintenance planner

Asset engineer: These transformers are the same age. Should they have the same replacement priority?

Maintenance planner: Age is one factor. Condition, loading, failure history, and consequence also matter.

Asset engineer: I'll compare those indicators using the current assessment method.

Maintenance planner: Include access, lead times, and planned outage constraints in the practical options.

Asset engineer: Then the asset review can assess risk and cost on a consistent basis.

Maintenance planner: I'll develop a maintenance schedule from the approved priorities rather than assume age alone determines the order.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "These transformers are the same age. Should they have the same replacement priority?"
What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Storm resource planning

An emergency team plans additional field resources.

Roles: Emergency coordinator / Resource planner

Emergency coordinator: The forecast suggests wider impacts. What resources are confirmed and what is still only requested?

Resource planner: Two crews are confirmed; mutual-aid availability remains pending.

Emergency coordinator: Keep those categories separate in the response plan.

Resource planner: I'll also verify travel, accommodation, skills, and site-specific briefing arrangements.

Emergency coordinator: Coordinate deployment through the authorized incident structure as conditions develop.

Resource planner: I'll maintain the resource status and flag any gap that affects the response options.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The forecast suggests wider impacts. What resources are confirmed and what is still only requested?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Efficiency program explanation

A program team reviews a savings claim.

Roles: Program analyst / Customer program manager

Program analyst: The brochure says every participant will save twenty percent. Our estimate doesn't support a universal promise.

Customer program manager: We should explain the assumptions and the factors that affect actual savings.

Program analyst: I'll separate modeled savings from measured outcomes and show the relevant range.

Customer program manager: Check eligibility, installation, and verification conditions in the current program terms too.

Program analyst: I'll revise the customer wording and send it for review.

Customer program manager: Then staff can explain the program accurately without guaranteeing an individual's result.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The brochure says every participant will save twenty percent. Our estimate doesn't support a universal promise." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Reliability dashboard

Managers compare interruption statistics.

Roles: Reliability analyst / Operations director

Reliability analyst: The figures changed after we revised the treatment of major events. The trend needs explanation.

Operations director: Show the definitions and the series on a comparable basis where possible.

Reliability analyst: I'll identify what is included, excluded, and affected by the methodology change.

Operations director: Can we still assess the maintenance program's contribution?

Reliability analyst: We can discuss the evidence, but shouldn't attribute the entire movement to one intervention.

Operations director: Good. Make the limitations visible before the investment recommendation goes to the executive team.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Can we still assess the maintenance program's contribution?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Grid Reliability and Outage Response

SHARED CASE

An outage update lists an affected area but the restoration estimate is still under assessment. A draft message gives a firm time.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

The affected area is identified, but restoration timing is still being assessed. I'll state what is confirmed and when customers should expect the next update rather than promise an unverified time.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Safety, Field Work, and Switching

SHARED CASE

During a language simulation, two documents use different equipment identifiers for a field task. Only authorized procedures govern the actual work.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The equipment identifiers do not match. Please have the authorized team resolve the discrepancy using the approved procedure. I will repeat the identifiers clearly to confirm that we are discussing the same equipment.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Regulatory Affairs and Rate Cases

SHARED CASE

A customer sees a proposed rate adjustment and assumes it is already in effect. The notice describes a proposal under review.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The notice describes a proposed adjustment, not a change already in effect. Let me show you the stated review process and where to find the current applicable tariff information.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Renewables Integration and Interconnection

SHARED CASE

A project team describes an interconnection application as an approved connection. Technical and administrative reviews are still open.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The application has been submitted, but the reviews are still open. I'll describe the current stage and remaining steps without implying that connection has already been authorized.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Asset Management and Maintenance

SHARED CASE

Two asset options have different purchase prices and maintenance needs. A budget slide compares only the purchase price.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The initial price is only one part of the comparison. Let's show the assumed maintenance, expected service period, and other relevant lifecycle costs so the decision reflects the full basis of the estimate.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Emergency Preparedness and Storm Response

SHARED CASE

A storm-response coordination shift has several requested resources but only some confirmed. The next coordinator needs the distinction.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Cover this until after your first attempt

These resources are confirmed; the others are still requested. I've separated their status and contact points in the handoff. Please confirm receipt and update the record when an assignment changes.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Customer Programs and Energy Efficiency

SHARED CASE

An efficiency program reports lower energy use after installation, but weather and occupancy also changed.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

Energy use fell after installation, but weather and occupancy changed too. I'll describe the measurement basis and remaining uncertainty before attributing the entire reduction to the program.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Executive Reliability and Investment Updates

SHARED CASE

A reliability presentation lists SAIDI and SAIFI without explanations. Community representatives need to understand the distinction.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

One measure summarizes average interruption duration and the other interruption frequency for the defined customer group. I'll explain both, state the reporting basis, and show what changed over the period.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

GHG Protocol: corporate standard

<https://ghgprotocol.org/corporate-standard>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.